

Setup guide

Please do these steps before the session. They take about 20 minutes. Stuck? Come 10 minutes early and our TAs (teaching assistants) will help.



Your to-do list

1. Choose your laptop.
2. Decide on your plan (Free is fine).
3. Install Claude and sign in.
4. Update the app.
5. Check your privacy setting.
6. Check the setting that skills need.
7. Download the practice files.
8. Do the two-minute self-test.

1 Choose your laptop

Bring a laptop where you can install software. We recommend:

- your **personal laptop**, or
- a KAUST laptop where you have **admin rights** (permission to install software yourself).

A KAUST laptop can't install software unless you have admin rights. **If that's the only laptop you have, bring it anyway.** Use Claude in your web browser at claude.ai for the Chat parts, and watch the rest. In step 3, skip the download and install. Skip step 4.

2 Decide on your plan

KAUST does not provide a Claude plan, so you'll use your own personal account.

- **Free is fine for most of the exercises.** You don't need to pay.
- **A paid plan (Pro or Max)** lets you do everything. Pay only if you want to. As of 27 September 2026, Pro costs \$20 a month (\$17 a month if you pay for a year), and Max starts at \$100 a month.

What each part of the session needs:

Part of the session	Free	Pro or Max
Chat: asking well and adding files (exercise 1)	Yes	Yes
Skills (exercise 2)	Yes	Yes
Projects and artifacts	Yes	Yes
Claude Code in the Code tab (exercise 3)	Do the same job in Chat instead	Yes
Cowork	Watch the demo	Watch the demo
Workflows	Watch the demo	Watch the demo

What these words mean:

- **Chat:** you type to Claude and it replies.
- **Skill:** a saved set of instructions that teaches Claude a task you repeat, so you don't have to explain it every time.
- **Project:** a space in Claude that keeps the files and instructions for one piece of work.
- **Artifact:** a document, page or chart Claude makes that opens next to the chat.

- **Claude Code:** Claude working directly on the files in a folder on your computer. You ask in plain words. You don't need to write code.
- **Cowork:** Claude doing a job on the files in a folder you choose, inside the Claude app.
- **Workflow:** here this means a Claude feature, not the everyday word: many Claude helpers work on one big job at the same time.

3 Install Claude and sign in

Browser only? Go straight to "Sign in" below and do it at claude.ai.

You need Windows 10 or later, or macOS 13 or later.

Download

1. Go to claude.com/download.
2. Click **Download for Windows** or **Download for macOS**.
 - Some Windows laptops have a Snapdragon chip. For those, click **Windows (arm64)** instead.
 - Not sure? On Windows, open **Settings > System > About** and look at **System type**. If it says "ARM-based processor", choose **Windows (arm64)**.

Install on Windows

1. Open your **Downloads** folder.
2. Double-click the Claude installer (the file you just downloaded).
3. When it finishes, open Claude from the **Start** menu.

If Windows asks for an administrator password you don't have, click **No**. Claude may still install. Cowork might not work on that laptop, but Cowork is only a demo on the day. If it won't install at all, use claude.ai in your browser instead.

Install on a Mac

1. Open your **Downloads** folder.
2. Double-click the Claude file. A small window opens.
3. Drag the **Claude** icon onto the **Applications** folder.
4. Open **Finder**, click **Applications**, and double-click **Claude**.
5. If your Mac asks "Are you sure you want to open it?", click **Open**.

If your Mac asks for an administrator password you don't have, use claude.ai in your browser instead.

Sign in

Click **Continue with Google**, or type your email address. If you use email, Claude sends you a sign-in link. Open it on the same laptop.

- Your KAUST email works. It still gives you a personal account, not a KAUST one.
- No email after 5 minutes? Check your **Junk** folder.
- You must be 18 or older to use Claude.

4 Update the app

Do this once now, and again the day before.

- **Windows:** in the Claude window's menu, choose **Help > Check for Updates**.
- **Mac:** click **Claude** in the menu bar at the top of the screen, then **Check for Updates**.

5 Check your privacy setting (before your first chat)

1. Click your **initials** at the bottom left of the Claude window.
2. Click **Settings**, then **Privacy**.
3. Find the switch "**Help improve our AI models**".

What it means:

- **On:** Anthropic, the company that makes Claude, may use your chats to improve Claude. It can keep them for up to 5 years.
- **Off:** your chats are not used for that. They stay in your list until you delete them. A chat you delete is removed within 30 days.

It's your choice. Switch it off if you'd rather your chats weren't used. We'll explain more in the session.

6 Check the setting that skills need

1. Click your **initials**, then **Settings**, then **Capabilities**.
2. Make sure "**Code execution and file creation**" is switched on. It is on by default.

This setting lets Claude make real files for you, like Word, Excel or PDF files. Skills need it. You won't write any code.

7 Download the practice files

We use practice files with made-up information only. They come as one **zip file** (a single file that holds a whole folder, packed up). You need to unpack ("unzip") it into your **Documents** folder.

1. Go to kaust-academy.github.io/2026_KAUST_Claude_Workshop, open the **Before** page, and download **practice-files.zip**.

On Windows

2. Open your **Downloads** folder.
3. **Right-click** practice-files.zip and choose **Extract All...**
4. Click **Browse**, click **Documents**, then click **Select Folder**.
5. Click **Extract**.

Don't just double-click the zip: that only lets you look inside, and Claude can't work there.

On a Mac

2. Open your **Downloads** folder.
3. If you already see a folder called **Claude-Practice**, your Mac unzipped it for you. If not, double-click **practice-files.zip**.
4. Drag the **Claude-Practice** folder into **Documents** (in the list on the left of the window).

Check it worked

Open **Documents > Claude-Practice**. You should see:

- README.txt
- 01-ask-well
- 02-skill
- 03-code
- 04-cowork

Windows may show "README" without the ".txt" at the end. That's fine.

Until the session, use only these practice files with Claude. Please don't connect your KAUST email or Google Drive to Claude yet.

8 The two-minute self-test

Open Claude and try these. If something doesn't work, note what you saw and tell a TA on the day.

1. **Say hello.** Click **New** in the left sidebar. Type *Say hello in English.* and press Enter. Claude should reply.
2. **Add a file.** Click **+** in the message box, then **Add files or photos**. Open **Documents > Claude-Practice > 01-ask-well** and pick **annual-report-2026**. Type *What is this file about, in one sentence?* and press Enter. Claude should describe a made-up annual report.
3. **Find your skills.** Click **Customize** in the left sidebar, then **Skills**. You should see a few ready-made skills. Don't add anything yet: we'll do that together.

4. **Look at the message box.** Do you see a **Chat | Cwork** choice, or one box with no choice? Both are fine. Remember which one you have.
5. **Paid plans only: try the Code tab.** On Free, clicking **Code** shows "Upgrade to Pro or Max to use Claude Code on the desktop." That's expected, so skip this step.
 1. Click **Code** at the top of the left sidebar.
 2. Choose **Local** (files on this computer).
 3. Click **Select folder...**, then **Open folder...**, and pick **Documents > Claude-Practice**.
 4. If Claude asks "Trust this workspace?", click **Trust workspace**. It's your practice folder, so that's safe.
 5. Click the mode button next to the send button and choose **Manual** ("Always ask before making changes"). A new folder starts in Auto, which may not ask, so this step matters.
 6. Type *Make a copy of README.txt called test.txt*. and press Enter.
 7. Claude should ask first, with the buttons **Deny**, **Always allow** and **Allow once**. Click **Allow once**.
 8. A file called test.txt now appears in Claude-Practice. You can leave it there.
 9. If Windows asks about "Git" (a tool Claude Code uses behind the scenes), update the app (step 4) and try again.

If a Mac asks whether Claude may use your Documents folder, click **Allow**.

Browser users: do tests 1 and 2 at claude.ai.

Optional: the text-window version of Claude Code

You don't need this on the day. It is for paid plans only, and for people who are curious.

Claude Code also runs in a **terminal**: the text window where you type commands. On Windows it is called **PowerShell**. On a Mac it is called **Terminal**.

1. Open the text window.
 - **Windows:** click **Start**, type *PowerShell*, and open **Windows PowerShell**.
 - **Mac:** press **Cmd+Space**, type *Terminal*, and press Enter.
2. Copy the install line (one line of text that installs Claude Code) **only from Claude's official page, code.claude.com/docs**, never from another website. As of 27 September 2026 it should match one of these:
 - **Windows (PowerShell):** `irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex`
 - **Mac (Terminal):** `curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash`
3. Paste it into the window (**Ctrl+V** on Windows, **Cmd+V** on a Mac) and press Enter. Wait until it finishes.
4. Close the window and open a new one.
5. Type `claude --version` and press Enter. You should see a version number followed by "(Claude Code)".

On the day

- **Arrive 10 minutes early.** TAs will help anyone who isn't set up yet.
- **Bring a charged laptop**, and its charger if you can.
- Can't install? Bring your laptop anyway and use claude.ai in your browser.

Why we ask you to use practice files only

Anything Claude reads, like a file you add or a folder you choose, is sent to Anthropic to be processed. Claude Code and Cwork can also change files in the folder you give them. So in the workshop we use made-up files only, and we give Claude one practice folder, never your whole Documents folder.

Don't put sensitive information into Claude. Follow KAUST policy on what you can and can't use.

These steps are accurate as of 27 September 2026. Claude's app changes often, so your screen may look a little different. That's fine: the TAs will help.